



ILLITERACY DUE TO POVERTY

Expository Writing Project Phase 1:
Critical Media Analysis



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Contributions:

Taha Ahmad: Introduction, Abstract, choosing of PSA

Juhayra Khan: Analysis Organisation, choosing of Movie Clip

Areesha Sajid: Initial topics Selection, choosing of Billboard

Meeshaam Abbasi: Conclusion + Recommendations

Abstract:

In this report, prepared as part of the Expository Writing course, we chose to address a growing issue regarding a timeless vision for education, and our group consisting of Meshaim Abbasi, Juhayra Khan, Areesha Jawad and Taha Ahmed, make up the group undertaking this project. Credit also belongs to Shivani Nallainathan, Phantom and HRX Films, NG Entertainment and The Citizen's Foundation for the resources used for putting this report together. Our main reason for our chosen topic can be encapsulated by the 4th SDG... the right to inclusive education. Another reason for this report is to critically examine illiteracy caused by poverty as a

serious social issue. We have achieved this through examination of media, billboards and a PSA. Our findings are compiled through reputable resources on the internet and live images of relevant movements and public efforts as well as the subtle but contrary opposition.

We talk about how media outlets such as movies, billboards and PSA's address their own area of effect on the issue and how. Although everything is limited by the sources we have selected... we attempt to decipher the underlying biases and broad implication of the design choices and film-making methods employed in the media, using neutral but critical thinking and judgement, and we've found each kind of media to be multifaceted, capable of conveying different messages on their own, but having conveyed the agendas of the producers of that media in the end, whether it be movies being more fit for a general audience and those unaware... and how billboards cater to the general public and their drive to act.

Introduction:

Education has always been the driving force for human society, yet has historically been limited by economic status, creating a divide between those who can afford learning and those who cannot, and as we can imagine, the way they're portrayed in society, especially through modern media, has gained nuance ever since its conception when education was made into a thing only the financially able could access. In this project, spearheaded by our Expository Writing course, we will address 3 specific sources, which are... a scene from the movie *Super 30*, the "Poverty & Education // Social Awareness Campaign" graphic, and The Citizen Foundation's Public Service Announcement video. Altogether, this report will analyze how these media forms represent educational inequality, the ideologies they promote, and their impact on audiences.

Representation of the Issue in Modern Media

Visual and Narrative Representation

If you look around at how modern media tackles educational inequality, it's clear that they lean into personal stories. Take the billboard ad for example. The harshness of the boy's surroundings isn't hidden. But right in the middle of the gloom, illustrated school supplies, a backpack, a notebook, pop out bright and hopeful. It's not subtle; rather, this use of visual juxtaposition reinforces the divide between poverty and opportunity. The kid's reality is bleak, but these supplies represent what he should have, what every child should have. The message isn't lost: educational opportunities exist somewhere in the world, just not where he is. Moreover, using a real photo with bright graphic overlays highlights how education isn't naturally part of his life; it has to be fought for or given to him.

Similarly, *Super 30* takes it further, swapping static images for full-blown human stories. Anand Kumar, brilliant at math, passionate about learning, finds himself kicked out of a library, not because he can't read, but because he doesn't fit the privileged mold. This reflects institutional exclusion, where access to knowledge is controlled by social class rather than ability. However, when his own book eventually gets placed on those same shelves, it flips the story. The earlier humiliation turns into triumph and proof that talent can break through

walls thrown up by society. Ultimately, the film doesn't gloss over reality. It follows injustice, perseverance, and eventual recognition, showing how the fight for equal access is messy, human, and ongoing.

Context of the Issue

Who is Affected

Worldwide, students are growing up where options are scarce, dreams outsized, but resources laughably small. Buying textbooks, paying bus fare, even having electricity to study by; none of these are guaranteed. Moreover, many have to work, too, not for pocket money, but to support their families. For them, school isn't just about

learning; it's a daily negotiation with hardship.

Where and Why the Issue Exists

Looking at where this issue pops up, it's usually in places with big gaps between rich and poor, developing countries, marginalized communities, areas where money decides everything. For instance, that billboard highlights kids in Sri Lanka, while *Super 30* deals with challenges in the Indian education system. Different countries, same story: your financial status lays out your chances for learning.

Target Audience

Billboard Audience

The billboard campaign is not aimed at the children it portrays but rather at financially capable individuals who can take action. Placed in high-traffic areas like stations and intersections, it delivers a quick, emotionally charged message, presenting the problem and solution within seconds. As a result, it appeals to people with a sense of social responsibility, encouraging immediate support through donations.

Film Audience

The audience for *Super 30* is broader, including students, educators, and general viewers. Some relate to Anand Kumar's struggles, while others view it as a critique of systemic inequality. Rather than directly asking for action, the film aims to shift perspectives, using storytelling to build empathy and highlight the value of education.

PSA Audience

The PSA targets individuals who are both financially capable and socially motivated, particularly during Ramzan when charitable giving is emphasized. By linking education with Zakat, it appeals to religious values and a sense of duty, encouraging viewers to contribute toward improving access to education for underprivileged children.

Purpose and Ideology

Social Message of the Billboard

Dig a little deeper and you'll see, these 3 media forms push more than just messages; they pack in serious opinions about who deserves an education and what society's supposed to do about it. The billboard doesn't just shake its head at the way things are; rather, it takes a stand, arguing that education isn't some privilege you win in a lottery. It belongs to everyone. By asking for donations, it's not letting you pretend someone else will step in.

Ideological Message of the Film

On the other hand, *Super 30* shows education as a fight, a real battle for fairness. You see Anand pushing through barriers that aren't always obvious, winning ground one hard day at a time. The movie keeps reinforcing it: talent isn't the problem, tradition and old rules are. At the same time, the story points right at failing institutions but keeps some hope alive, too, change has to start at the bottom, and it matters. In contrast, the PSA promotes a more solution-oriented ideology, presenting education as a shared social responsibility and emphasizing that change begins through collective effort and support, rather than individual struggle alone.

Comparison of Media Forms

Differences in Communication Style

Put them next to each other and they couldn't feel more different. The billboard is like lightning, fast, bold, meant to shake you awake. You don't get to linger; it's made to startle you into action, right on the spot. Its message is upfront and urgent: see the problem, do something, now. The film, however, is different. *Super 30*, through conversations, losses, and tiny wins, walks you through why injustice sticks around, and why there's no quick fix. Watching Anand, you don't just notice the issue once, you dig into where it comes from, watch how it messes with his, and by extension, other students' lives. Overall, films let you soak in the message, maybe spot contradictions, and sit with them a while, while the billboard shouts for action; and lastly the PSA brings a bit of both action and reflection forward.

Impact on the Audience

Lasting Emotional Impact

All 3 types of media push you to see that this is more than statistics or rules, it's about real people, their setbacks, their grit, and what's at stake if nothing changes. Specifically the movie clip, *Super 30*, doesn't just expose one bad moment; you live it, you wait out the struggle, and when Anand finally breaks through, his victory and all that came before linger with you. The story stays in your head, reshaping what "opportunity" sounds like, and who actually gets one. Similarly, the PSA is designed to create immediate impact, particularly by linking the issue to Ramzan and Zakat, which increases the likelihood of audience response by aligning the message with existing values and motivations.

Conclusion:

In conclusion, the media analysis shows that the students from low-income and marginalized backgrounds have faced serious challenges due to poverty. Educational inequality, as demonstrated across all media forms analyzed, remains a persistent consequence. Many students do not get proper opportunities due to financial problems and lack of resources which affect their mental health and they lose motivation. Through our analysis, we have shown that the media creates a strong impact on the people by bringing awareness to them about the struggle of getting education due to poverty. To sum up, these media forms not only highlight inequality but also shape how audiences understand responsibility, opportunity, and access to knowledge in modern society.

Recommendations:

Billboards

- Billboards should represent the real-life images of students who face difficulty in getting education and how poverty limits the opportunity. It should also clearly represent the importance of education.
- There should be simple language and visuals so that people from different groups can understand it clearly and the general public can help low-income families.

Movies

- Movies should focus on real-life stories of students who are struggling with financial barriers so that people can understand that poverty blocks knowledge.
- Movies should give us the understanding of social issues and spread awareness about the challenges of educational inequality.

PSA

- PSA should use the emotional language and strong visuals to represent every children dreams to get good education but because of poverty there dream never come true. It makes the issue clear and relatable.
- It should focus on targeting the large audience through simple and powerful messages and should encourage people to support and respond quickly to this social issue

References

Billboard: <https://shivaniinallainathan.com/poverty-education-social-awareness-campaign>

Advertisement:(public service announcement)

<https://www.facebook.com/TCFPak/videos/education-is-the-dream-of-every-child-yet-millions-are-held-back-due-to-barriers/924636530335972/>

Movie Clip: https://www.youtube.com/shorts/W_km3UGCWV8

Reference Article 1: [The Measurement of Education and Poverty: An Analysis of Pakistani Society | Journal of Social and Organizational Matters](#)